

entrenched; and investor confidence, once lost, will take time to rebuild. But he sketches an unapologetically market-oriented agenda: simpler land laws, land pooling, deregulation, privatisation, better infrastructure, lower taxes, tighter compliance and a push to combine manufacturing with services and deep technology.

Underlying it all is a larger political ambition to recover Bengal's old commercial self-belief. In this interview with Siddharth Zarabi, Dasgupta explains why the new government wants to overturn the perception that Bengal is anti-business, why he believes welfare must become more targeted, and what it will take for West Bengal to aspire once again to be one of India's fastest-growing states. Edited excerpts:

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West Bengal occupied a very special place in India's economy. It was once an industrial powerhouse. With the massive political mandate for the Bharatiya Janata Party to rule the state, can we hope for a new sunrise?

First, this mandate was partly a vote against misgovernance, but I think far more important was a degree of exasperation and impatience with a prolonged period of decline which West Bengal has

been experiencing, for the past 50 years at least. The message that went out to the world was that if the Tatas cannot do business in West Bengal, then who are we to do anything?

And then there was the human cost. One of the things which I discovered when campaigning in the

industry, which had great traction at that time.

Obviously, we are not going to get that back. But what I think you can get back is a combination of manufacturing, a boom in services and, most importantly, an injection of deep tech into West Bengal. We have lost out to Gujarat, to

WE MUST DO MORE DEREGULATION AND PRIVATISATION. WE NEED TO LEVERAGE OUR EXISTING DEAD ASSETS TO HAVE A HEALTHY BUDGET

heart of South Calcutta was that it had become a city of old-age pensioners. So, we suffer from a huge skills deficit. Bengalis are in top places all over the world. They are very accomplished, but they are not in Bengal. They have taken a one-way ticket out.

One of the things which is very important is to address the perception that Bengalis particularly tend to be anti-business—we must reverse that.

You had 20% of the world's GDP at one time coming from Bengal, particularly concentrated around Murshidabad because of the silk

Karnataka, and Odisha.

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Why should businesses choose to now invest in Bengal?

If you look at it purely in terms of incentives, there are states which do better. What we are saying is: we have an ecosystem in place, a skilled workforce and a reasonably liveable city. We also have a rich repository of people who know how to handle money, and a breed of indigenous potential entrepreneurs.

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Should businesses be confident that if they

seek large pieces of land, it will not become a flashpoint?

Land is always a ticklish issue in West Bengal because of two reasons: it is in short supply, and land holdings tend to be of handkerchief size.

And on top of that, there are infuriatingly complex land tenures created by the predecessor regimes under the Left. So, we first need a large amount of legislation to simplify it.

Secondly, outright acquisition by the government can be done in certain cases, but I think what is necessary is to have other forms of incentives. We are experimenting with land pooling arrangements, which have been successfully done in Gujarat and Haryana. But land is always going to be an issue in Bengal.

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What needs to be done by your state when it comes to the restless Gen Z?

Youth unrest in West Bengal is not a new thing. What the rest of India is experiencing, we have been there before. What is important now is to create an environment where people can stay on. We need to improve the education infrastructure, create a greater degree of hunger for people to enrich themselves and have a greater degree of civic pride. The sense of hopelessness must be broken.